worth of Rs 375 crore. Also, as a former senior official said, "The political instability in the state means it is very much an MLA-governed state."

HOW TO SAVE BENGALURU FROM SELF-DESTRUCTION

What will it take for Bengaluru to get out of the collective hell-hole it finds itself in, as Ravichandar terms it? Can the city be saved? Yes, says Narayana Murthy. But with three caveats: that its administration be placed under the command of a CEO-like figure and all civic and infrastructure agencies report to him or her; the person chosen to head the unified command be someone of political stature (Murthy cites the example of Jawaharlal Nehru and Sardar Patel who cut their teeth in city politics and development before they became prime ministers. In the UK, it was former British prime minister Boris Johnson's performance as the mayor of London that catapulted him to the top post); and three, a portion of the enormous revenue that Bengaluru generates for the state be ploughed back into its development.

Others suggest that Bengaluru, like other major international cities, draw up a master plan with a 50-year vision, as Singapore did, and work towards it. Narasimhan disagrees, though. He argues that master plans for fast-growing cities like Bengaluru are an outdated idea, because it is based on land use, which is a euphemism for real estate. "It's like a colouring book," he says. "Yellow means residential, blue means commercial, red means government and green means public pace. This is all motherhood and apple pie stuff." Narasimhan says the rest of the world is abandoning such fossil fuel-era planning and instead repopulating the inner city because planners believe that urban density is better than urban spread. Narasimhan, therefore, wants a vision for the city that defines how air quality should be, the per capita water availability, the standards of mobility, the spaces for interactivity—criteria that define the quality of life a city hopes to offer rather than just buildings and roads, and then ensure these are implemented. London, for instance, decided that every single land transit vehicle, including cabs, metros and buses, be brought under a single organisation called Transport for London. It became so successful that people stopped using personal vehicles for office commutes, with many office complexes even abandoning parking spaces for vehicles.

AMONG THE SUGGESTIONS TO SAVE BENGALURU IS GETTING IT A CEO-LIKE FIGURE WHOM ALL AGENCIES CAN REPORT TO, AND TO PLOUGH BACK SOME OF ITS REVENUE INTO ITS DEVELOPMENT

The key, though, is time-bound implementation of civic infrastructure projects, with high-quality standards, something that Prashant Prakash, a serial entrepreneur and start-up investor, says is a major lacuna currently. Prakash argues that what the city administration lacks is the capacity to design and find solutions that are appropriate and contract them so that the work is done diligently rather than the suboptimal and substandard outcomes that have become the norm. Rather than rely on consultants for design and contractors for implementation of projects—neither of whom has much skin in the long-term game—he believes the government should leverage the competence of the vibrant private sector and form public-private partnerships to resolve civic amenity issues. He cites the example of Bengaluru Solid Waste Management Limited (BSWML), an autonomous body that was formed recently to handle the city's garbage. Administratively and financially independent, it will be free to enter into tie-ups to meet its goals.

What about developing a twin city for Bengaluru that can decongest the existing one? Many experts, including Ravichandar, are enthused by the idea and believe the Bangalore International Airport area, which covers 437 sq. km, could be developed into an alternative magnet if planned well. But real estate tycoon Irfan Razack, chairman of the Prestige Group, is against any move that detracts focus from Bengaluru and its collapsing infrastucture. "Bangalore is having a heart attack," he says. "It won't help the city if you operate on another body." Bommai believes the solution lies in developing satellite towns around the city and connecting them to Bengaluru with high-speed circular rail facilities. The central government has stepped in and sanctioned Rs 15,700 crore to boost the city's suburban rail network, a project PM Modi inaugurated and which he promised will be completed in 40 months and not 40 years. In addition, Bommai has announced that work will begin on the 74-km, eight-lane Peripheral Ring Road (PRR), a project estimated to cost Rs 15,000 crore. The recent floods and the damage they caused is a wake-up call for Bengaluru and gives Bommai and Co the opportunity to take tough decisions that can pull Bengaluru out of the current morass. This includes holding elections for the BBMP and devolving management to elected corporators, who will be accountable to the citizens. What is needed is speedy, concerted action to rescue India's city of the future from turning into a fossil of past follies. ■